FUTURES MATTER EDUCATION

Futures Matter - Northwood, 122 Emily Street, Highgate, Birmingham, B12 0XJ

Admissions Policy

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1.0 AIMS

Futures Matter Education Ltd has produced this policy so that children and young people are admitted to Futures Matter - Northwood through a fair, clear and robust process. We will take all reasonable steps to make sure we can meet the needs of every pupil we admit.

This policy aims to:

- explain how a child or young person is referred to the school, and how their family and placing local authority can take part
- set out how we decide whether we can meet a pupil's needs, and how we allocate places
- explain how a decision can be questioned or challenged
- make sure key entry and exit details for every pupil are checked and recorded at the start and end of their placement

2.0 LEGISLATION AND GUIDANCE

Futures Matter - Northwood is an independent special school. The School Admissions Code and the School Admission Appeals Code apply to state-funded schools, so they do not apply to us. We follow their principles of fairness, clarity and objectivity, and this policy is based on the following.

- The Children and Families Act 2014 (Part 3) and the Special Educational Needs and Disability Regulations 2014, which cover Education, Health and Care (EHC) plans and the placement of children with special educational needs
- The SEND Code of Practice: 0 to 25 years, DfE, which sets out how local authorities consult schools about placements
- The Equality Act 2010, which prevents us discriminating in our admission arrangements and requires reasonable adjustments for disabled pupils
- The Education (Independent School Standards) Regulations 2014, including the duty to provide information to parents about our admission arrangements
- The Education (Pupil Registration) (England) Regulations 2006, which set out what an admission register must hold and when a pupil can be removed from it
- Keeping Children Safe in Education (KCSIE) 2026, which covers safeguarding information when a pupil joins or leaves
- Children Missing Education: Statutory Guidance for Local Authorities, DfE, which covers pupils whose destination is unknown

3.0 DEFINITIONS

- **EHC plan:** an Education, Health and Care plan made by a local authority under the Children and Families Act 2014
- **Placing authority:** the local authority that is responsible for the pupil's EHC plan and that commissions and funds the placement
- **Parent:** anyone who holds parental responsibility under the Children Act 1989, or who has care of the child and with whom the child lives, either full or part time
- **Looked-after child:** a child who is in the care of a local authority, or is provided with accommodation by a local authority (section 22 of the Children Act 1989)

- **Previously looked-after child:** a child who was looked after but has left care because they were adopted, or became subject to a child arrangements order or a special guardianship order
- **Referral:** a request from a placing authority or family for us to consider a pupil for a place
- **Admission register:** the register we must keep of every pupil admitted to the school (see section 13.0)

4.0 RESPONSIBILITIES

4.1 Futures Matter Education Ltd and the Proprietor

Futures Matter Education Ltd will make sure that:

- the school only admits pupils whose needs it can meet at the point of admission
- every referral is dealt with efficiently and within the timescales in this policy
- there is a clear and fair process for referring pupils
- there is a structured, supportive admission and induction process
- the future destination of every pupil who leaves is checked, and where it is not correct for a pupil of school age, we tell the local authority promptly

4.2 The School: Futures Matter - Northwood

The school will follow this policy, and handle every referral promptly, professionally and with respect for the child and family. If we become approved under Section 41 (see section 5.3), we will also follow the requirements that come with that listing.

4.3 The Head Teacher and the Designated Safeguarding Lead

The Head Teacher makes the decision on whether to offer a place, with advice from relevant staff. The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL) makes sure safeguarding information about every new pupil is received and read before they start, and is passed on when they leave.

5.0 OUR SCHOOL AND WHO WE ADMIT

5.1 Our School

Futures Matter - Northwood is a mixed independent special school for pupils aged 11 to 16 (Years 7 to 11) with social, emotional and mental health (SEMH) needs and autism. Some pupils also have moderate learning difficulties or speech, language and communication needs. Every pupil must have an EHC plan.

5.2 Number of Places

The school is registered for up to 20 pupils. Because we are a specialist school that admits through referral from placing authorities, we do not have a single point of entry or a fixed admission date. We admit pupils throughout the year, whenever a place is available, we can meet the pupil's needs and a placement has been agreed.

5.3 Section 41

The school is not currently on the Section 41 list of approved independent special schools. We intend to apply in the future. If we are approved, we will admit any pupil whose EHC plan names the school, as the law then requires (section 43 of the Children and Families Act 2014), and we will update this policy.

5.4 Equality and Fairness

We do not discriminate against any pupil or family on the basis of a protected characteristic in deciding whether to offer a place, or in the terms on which we offer it. We make reasonable adjustments to our admission process for pupils with autism and other needs, for example by arranging quieter visits, shorter or repeated visits, visual information and extra time to prepare.

6.0 HOW TO APPLY

6.1 Who Can Refer

Referrals normally come from the placing authority, through its consultation process, with the child's EHC plan. Referrals and in-year applications should be sent to benjamin.neasom@futuresmattereducation.co.uk or, as an alternative, office@futuresmattereducation.co.uk, or posted to the Head Teacher at Futures Matter - Northwood, 122 Emily Street, Highgate, Birmingham, B12 0XJ. Parents and carers who would like us to be considered can contact the school by email at benjamin.neasom@futuresmattereducation.co.uk or office@futuresmattereducation.co.uk, or by phone on 0121 835 1360, and we will explain what to ask their local authority to send. We cannot offer a place without an EHC plan and an agreed placement with the placing authority.

6.2 Information We Need

To consider a referral properly, we need as much of the following as possible.

- the EHC plan, and the most recent annual review and any reports it refers to
- reports from educational psychologists, speech and language therapists, occupational therapists, health professionals and other agencies
- information about behaviour, including any incidents, risk assessments, behaviour plans and use of physical intervention
- safeguarding and child protection information, including whether the child has a social worker or is looked after
- details of the pupil's current or previous school, attendance and any periods out of education
- the pupil's own views and the views of their parents or carers
- contact details for the placing authority and information about funding

6.3 What Happens After a Referral

Stage	What happens
1. Receive	We acknowledge the referral within 5 working days and tell the placing authority if anything is missing.
2. Review	The Head Teacher reviews the documents and decides whether we think we can meet the pupil's needs (see section 8.0). We aim to respond in writing within 15 working days of receiving a complete referral.
3. Home visit	Where possible, the Head Teacher arranges a home visit with the family and the placing authority to meet the pupil and hear their views.

Stage	What happens
4. School visit	The pupil is invited to visit the school, tour the building and meet staff, at a pace that suits them. We can arrange more than one visit.
5. Decision	If a visit goes well and we are confident we can meet needs, the Head Teacher sends the placing authority an offer with a suggested start date.
6. Agree and start	When the placing authority accepts, we confirm this with the parents and carers and agree contracts and funding (see section 11.0). We then confirm the start date and transition arrangements, and welcome the pupil through a personalised induction.

7.0 PROSPECTUS AND INFORMATION FOR FAMILIES

We publish a prospectus, and keep it available at the school office and on our website. It includes:

- the school's name, address and website address
- a named contact person
- the school roll, age range, phase, and that the school is mixed
- the classification of the school (an independent special school)
- the primary and secondary needs we support
- how admissions work

We also publish this Admissions Policy on our website and make it available on request, so that parents, carers and placing authorities can see how decisions are made.

8.0 DECIDING WHETHER WE CAN MEET A PUPIL'S NEEDS

8.1 What We Consider

We will only offer a place if we are satisfied that:

- the special educational needs in the EHC plan and other records can be met within our resources, or with additional resources that can reasonably be provided
- we have the staff, training and expertise the pupil needs, or can put them in place before they start
- we can keep the pupil and other pupils safe, taking account of the needs of the current group
- the pupil's age, needs and prior learning fit our curriculum and provision
- a risk assessment has been completed before admission, where possible, or on admission

We will not refuse a pupil because of a disability or because of the nature of their SEMH or autism needs alone.

8.2 Behaviour that Challenges

Our pupils have SEMH needs, so behaviour that challenges is not in itself a reason to refuse a place. We may decline a referral where, after considering reasonable adjustments and the support and resources that could be put in place, we cannot meet the pupil's needs or keep

the pupil and others safe. The Head Teacher will record the reasons in writing, discuss them with the placing authority and, where it would help, explore what extra support or resource could make a placement possible.

9.0 ALLOCATING PLACES

9.1 When a Place is Available

If we have a place and we can meet the pupil's needs, we will offer it. We do not use catchment areas, sibling links, feeder schools or selection by ability.

9.2 More Than One Suitable Referral

If we have more suitable referrals than places, we will allocate places in the following order, using only referrals for pupils whose needs we have confirmed we can meet.

1. Looked-after children and previously looked-after children.
2. Children who do not currently have a school place, including those who have been permanently excluded or have a long-term break in attendance.
3. All other children.

These criteria are applied fairly and do not disadvantage any child because of their disability, race or other characteristic.

9.3 Tie-Break

If two or more referrals cannot be separated by the criteria in 9.2, we will give priority to the referral for which a complete set of information was received first. If these are still equal, the Head Teacher will decide and record the reasons.

9.4 Waiting List

If we cannot offer a place straight away, we will keep suitable referrals on a waiting list for the school year and tell the placing authority and family. Each time a child is added, the list is ranked again using the criteria in 9.2 and 9.3, so the position is not decided only by when a child was added. When a place becomes available, it is offered in that order. We review the list each term.

9.5 Vulnerable Children and Fair Access

As an independent school we are not part of the local authority's Fair Access Protocol. We work with placing authorities to help unplaced and vulnerable children get a suitable place as quickly as possible, and looked-after children have priority in section 9.2.

9.6 Children of UK Service Personnel and Crown Servants

Where the family of a member of the UK armed forces or a crown servant has a confirmed posting, we can consider a referral before the family arrives, if the placing authority sends an official letter confirming the relocation date.

9.7 Requests to Join a Different Year Group

Parents can ask for a pupil to be admitted to a year group outside their normal age group. The request should be made to the Head Teacher in writing, through the placing authority where possible, with supporting information. We will decide in writing within 15 working days, on the circumstances of each case and the best interests of the pupil, taking account of:

- the parents' views

- information about the pupil's academic, social and emotional development
- where relevant, their medical history and the views of a medical professional
- whether they have previously been educated out of their normal age group
- whether they might naturally have been in a lower year group if they had not been born prematurely
- the Head Teacher's views

We will give the reasons for any decision. A request will not be treated as lower priority because it asks for a different year group.

10.0 OFFERS, WITHDRAWAL AND CHALLENGING A DECISION

10.1 Offers

We tell the placing authority and the parents and carers of our decision in writing. An offer includes a suggested start date and any conditions, such as the contract being signed or an assessment being completed.

10.2 Withdrawing an Offer

We will not withdraw an offer unless:

- it was made in error
- the placing authority or parents have not responded within a reasonable time, after we have given them another chance to respond and explained that the offer may be withdrawn
- the offer was based on false or misleading information, or important information was withheld
- new information before the start date shows that we can no longer meet the pupil's needs or keep them safe, and we have first discussed this with the placing authority and the family

We will not withdraw a place once a pupil has started, except where it was obtained fraudulently, and in that case we will consider how long the pupil has been with us. Withdrawing a place for any other reason would go through our Suspension and Exclusion Policy or a review with the placing authority.

10.3 If We Cannot Offer a Place

We will tell the placing authority and the parents and carers in writing, with our reasons. The placing authority remains responsible for finding a suitable placement.

10.4 If You Disagree with a Decision

The School Admission Appeals Code does not apply to us. Parents who disagree about which school is named in their child's EHC plan can use the rights set out in the SEND Code of Practice, including asking the placing authority to review the plan and appealing to the First-tier Tribunal (Special Educational Needs and Disability). If you are unhappy with how we have handled a referral, you can make a complaint under our Complaints Policy.

11.0 BEFORE A PUPIL STARTS

Before a pupil starts, we will make sure that:

- contractual arrangements are agreed with the placing authority, through a completed National Schools Contract and funding agreement letter, or the placing authority's own contract
- all contracts, consents and permissions are signed by the placing authority and the parents or carers
- we have seen proof of the pupil's age and identity, and know who holds parental responsibility
- safeguarding and child protection information has been received and read by the DSL, and we hold at least two emergency contacts
- baseline information and any assessment details are available before the post-admission review
- a risk assessment is in place, and any individual behaviour plan, health care plan or communication plan is ready
- we have identified the staff, resources and expertise needed to meet the pupil's individual needs
- a personalised induction and transition plan has been agreed with the pupil and family

Appendix 1 is the checklist we use to record this.

12.0 AFTER A PUPIL STARTS

A post-admission review takes place within twelve weeks. It confirms whether the placement is right, and agrees the pupil's learning programme and any behaviour plan. All those involved, including the pupil, parents and carers, the placing authority and relevant professionals, are invited. The review uses up-to-date, detailed assessment information, and risk assessments are reviewed at this point and regularly after.

13.0 ADMISSION REGISTER

13.1 What the Register Holds

We keep an admission register with an index of every pupil admitted to the school. For each pupil it records:

- Unique Pupil Number (UPN)
- full name and sex
- date of birth
- the name and address of every parent known to the school, with an indication of any parent the pupil normally lives with and an emergency telephone number
- the date of admission or re-admission
- the name and address of the school last attended, if any
- the date they leave, and their leaving destination

We keep the register securely and in line with data protection law, and we keep it for at least three years after the date of the last entry.

13.2 Leaving the School

When a pupil leaves, we check and record their destination. Where the destination is another school, we confirm that it is a legally registered provider. Where the destination is unknown, or is not a registered school, we tell the local authority promptly.

13.3 Removing a Pupil from the Register

We tell the local authority about any pupil who is going to be removed from the register because they:

- have been taken out of school by their parents and are being educated outside the school system, for example home education
- have ceased to attend school
- have been certified by a medical professional as unlikely to be fit to attend before they reach the end of compulsory school age
- are in custody for more than four months because of a final court order, and the Proprietor does not reasonably expect them to return at the end of that period
- have been permanently excluded

We tell the local authority as soon as we know the reason for removal, and no later than the date the pupil's name is removed. This duty is essential and we always comply with it.

14.0 MONITORING ARRANGEMENTS

The Head Teacher reviews this policy at least every year, and sooner if the law or DfE guidance changes. At every review, the policy is approved by the Proprietor and the School Governance Board. The Head Teacher reports to the School Governance Board on referrals received, places offered and declined, and the reasons, so that the Board can check that decisions are fair and consistent. We share the policy with the placing authorities we work with.

15.0 LEGISLATION, GUIDANCE AND REFERENCES

- The Children and Families Act 2014
- The Special Educational Needs and Disability Regulations 2014
- Special Educational Needs and Disability Code of Practice: 0 to 25 years, DfE
- The Equality Act 2010
- The Children Act 1989
- The Education (Independent School Standards) Regulations 2014
- The Education (Pupil Registration) (England) Regulations 2006
- Keeping Children Safe in Education (KCSIE) 2026
- Children Missing Education: Statutory Guidance for Local Authorities, DfE
- School Admissions Code (for its principles of fairness; it does not apply to independent schools), DfE
- Model Admissions Policy and Admissions Policy Checklist, The Key, October 2024

16.0 RELATED POLICIES

- Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy

- Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy
- Special Educational Needs Policy
- Curriculum Policy
- Complaints Policy
- Suspension and Exclusion Policy

17.0 APPENDICES

Appendix 1: Admission and Transition Checklist

APPENDIX 1: ADMISSION AND TRANSITION CHECKLIST

The Head Teacher, or a member of staff they name, completes this checklist for every pupil. All items should be done before the pupil starts, apart from the post-admission review.

ADMISSION CHECKLIST - Pupil name and date of birth:	
Referral received (date, from whom, complete or not):	
Referral reviewed by the Head Teacher (date, decision):	
Home visit (date, by whom):	
School visit(s) (dates, adjustments made):	
Needs we are meeting and resources needed:	
Risk assessment completed (date):	
Safeguarding information received and read by the DSL (date):	
Offer sent to placing authority (date, start date):	
Contract and funding letter signed (date):	
Consents and permissions signed (date):	
Proof of age and identity seen; person with parental responsibility confirmed:	
Two emergency contacts recorded:	
Behaviour, health care and communication plans in place:	
Personalised induction and transition plan agreed:	
Entered on the admission register (date, UPN):	
Post-admission review booked (within 12 weeks):	